

Diploma Guidelines

Overview diploma process

1. Submission of statement of intent and abstract of master's thesis (*diskursive Arbeit*)
2. Writing of master's thesis incl. Declaration of Autonomy Master-Thesis
3. Portfolio
4. Material expenses
5. Participation in examination colloquium as part of ZHdK diploma exhibition (*Diplomausstellung*)
6. Diploma award
7. Deadlines

1. Statement of intent and abstract of master's thesis

At the beginning of the autumn semester, students must submit a statement of intent and abstract of their master's thesis (use official form → "[Master's Thesis Statement of Intent and Abstract](#)") to the DFA Student Office (studium.dfa@zhdk.ch). Based on their submission, students will be assigned thesis mentors.

2. Writing of master's thesis

Students write their master's thesis during the last autumn semester of their MFA programme. The thesis presents and reflects on a topic or question of students' own choice. Students decide the format of their thesis in association with their mentor. Acceptable formats vary from artistic reflections through theoretical writing to experimental essays.

Students are required to request and attend three advisory appointments: a first appointment to discuss the concept of their master's thesis; a second appointment to receive feedback on the first version of one's thesis (before handing in first version); and a final appointment before submission deadline for the final version of master's thesis. Additional meetings may be arranged as needed with the supervising lecturer.

In addition to supervision, various instructional formats are offered during the autumn semester to support students in writing their master's theses.

Thesis requirements:

- The thesis consists of a written text or includes a written part.
- Length: min. 30'000 and max. 60'000 characters (including spaces).
- The thesis should be discursive, i.e. present substantiated arguments and/or incorporate various positions on a topic.
- Establishing a connection between one's thesis and artistic practice is desirable.

*With the submission of the final version of the master's thesis, the student is automatically registered for the diploma examination (Diplomprüfung). Important: to be eligible for registration, the student is also required to have earned **at least 90 ECTS credits** and to have studied at least three but no more than five semesters.*

The declaration of Autonomy form ([Declaration of Autonomy MA.docx \(live.com\)](#)) must be signed and handed in with the final version of the master's thesis.

3. Portfolio

A portfolio is submitted for the examination and to be shared on the ZHdK diploma website. The portfolio has max. 20 pages including a CV and optionally an artist statement. The maximum file size is 7 MB. Each work in the portfolio should have at least one image (ideally one image/work per page) including captions (title, year, material/technique) and ideally/optional a brief description of the work. The portfolio should represent work done within the last two years.

4. Material expenses

A total budget of CHF 500.00 is allocated to every final-year student for producing his or her diploma exhibition project. To be granted their budget, students are required to send a description of their diploma exhibition project, materials specification and the complete filled out form "[Diploma Exhibition Material Expenses](#)" to the DFA Student Office (studium.dfa@zhdk.ch). Materials may only be purchased after approval of the budget by the Head of MFA programme.

Please note: due to the regulations of Canton Zurich, we are not allowed to compensate any costs for technical equipment such as hardware, software, USB, hard drives, photo cameras and any other technical tools.

5. Examination colloquium

Examination colloquia are held before the opening of the official ZHdK diploma exhibition. Students are required to present and discuss their thesis-related artwork and master's thesis. Examinations last 40 minutes. The Head of MFA programme will announce the colloquia infrastructure and space.

Diploma examination criteria are specified in § 14 of the MFA Diploma Programme Regulations ([Studienordnung MA Fine Arts](#)).

6. Diploma award

To obtain the Master of Fine Arts diploma, students must complete 120 ECTS credits in accordance with the programme regulations, including 90 credits in the Major and 30 in the Minor, as well as all required modules and the diploma examination.

Major Fine Arts:

- Practice, min. 54 Credits from C-Modules
 - Context, min. 15 Credits, of which 3 Credits from C-Modules and 12 Credits from CE-Modules
 - Graduation, min. 21 Credits from C-Modules
- (Key: C = Compulsory Module; CE = Compulsory Elective Module)

Major Art:ifical Studies:

- Practice, min. 54 Credits from C-Modules
 - Context & Technology, min. 15 Credits from CE-Modules
 - Graduation, min. 21 Credits from C-Modules
- (Key: C = Compulsory Module; CE = Compulsory Elective Module)

The exact regulation can be found in the [Leitfaden/Student Guide](#).

7. Deadlines

Submission deadlines: [See official form "Master Fine Arts Dates & Deadlines Autumn/Spring Term"](#)

Task	Deadline	Submit to
1 st submission deadline for master's thesis (first version)	Friday of calendar week 03	Thesis supervisor (by e-mail)
2 nd submission deadline for master's thesis (final version) incl. declaration of Autonomy	Monday of calendar week 08	E-mail PDF and 5 printed copies to the DFA Student Office (room 6.A10)
Submission deadline for statement of intent and abstract of master's thesis	Monday of calendar week 08	DFA Student Office (by e-mail)
Material expenses	Friday of calendar week 12	DFA Student Office (by e-mail)
Submission deadline: Portfolio	See Dates & Deadlines Sheet	SWITCHdrive (instructions by Eva Vögtli)